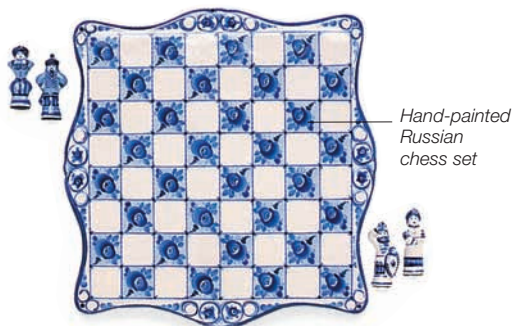




Hand-painted Russian chess set

CHESS

The ancient game of chess became popular in Russia as a way of spending long, dark winter evenings by the fireside. Today, chess is still widely played here. Russian Grand Masters such as Karpov and Spassky have dominated world chess tournaments. During a big match, giant chessboards are displayed in big city squares so the public can follow the competitors' moves.

LIVING IN A COLD CLIMATE

The Yakut people of eastern Siberia are used to living in a cold climate – winter temperatures drop to -45°F (-43°C). Engines are kept running 24 hours a day to prevent them from freezing up. Drinking water is delivered as chunks of ice sawn out of the local river. Even during the brief summer, most ground remains frozen hard. Houses are often built on raised concrete platforms or wooden stilts to protect them from frost damage.

The Yakut survive the winter by wearing many layers of warm clothing made from animal skins and fur. People wear felt or reindeer-fur boots, rather than leather, which freezes and cracks quickly.



Fur hats with ear-flaps protect their wearers from Russian winters.

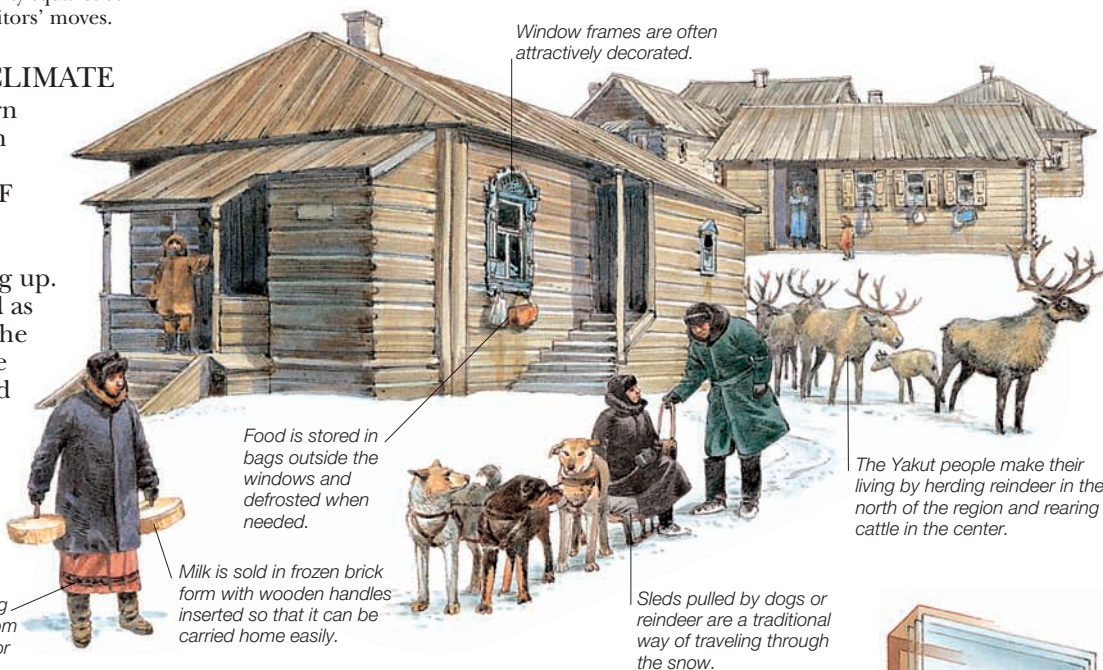
FUR FARMS

For centuries, hunters and trappers have worked the Siberian forests to catch ermine, mink, sable, lynx, and fox. In order to protect some species from over-hunting, the Soviet government introduced fur farms, where breeders raise rare animals for their furs. Furs from Siberian animals are turned into hats, coats, and linings for boots and gloves.



FORESTRY

The taiga forest of northern Russia and Siberia provides work in logging, paper production, chemicals, and furniture making. In the past, most forestry jobs were in the more accessible parts of northern Russia. But many of these forests have been cleared, and new seedlings take up to 80 years to produce mature wood. As a result, the center of the forestry industry has moved south and east into Siberia. Today, most lumber production is located in southern Siberia near Lake Baikal or on the Amur River near the Pacific coast.



Window frames are often attractively decorated.

Food is stored in bags outside the windows and defrosted when needed.

Milk is sold in frozen brick form with wooden handles inserted so that it can be carried home easily.

The Yakut people make their living by herding reindeer in the north of the region and rearing cattle in the center.

Sleds pulled by dogs or reindeer are a traditional way of traveling through the snow.



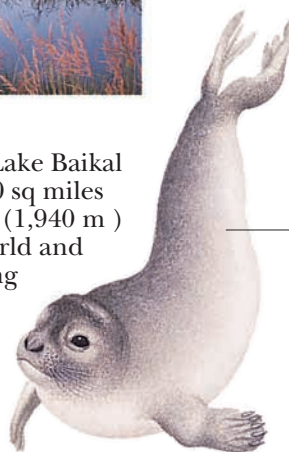
LAKE BAIKAL

Known as the "blue eye of Siberia," Lake Baikal in southeastern Siberia covers 12,150 sq miles (31,468 sq km) and is up to 6,367 ft (1,940 m) deep. It is the deepest lake in the world and the largest freshwater lake, containing more than 20 percent of the world's entire supply of freshwater. In recent years, logging and chemical industries have polluted the water, prompting a major campaign to protect this unique environment.

Windows are triple-glazed to keep out the cold. The air between the three layers of glass acts as insulation.



Lake Baikal is home to the world's only freshwater seal, the nerpa, or Baikal seal. A wide variety of flora and fauna, unique to the area, are found in and around the lake.



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